

“When face-to-face with evil, I just refuse to back down...”

**RAJNI PANDIT, 42**

**HEAD OF:** Rajani  
Investigation Bureau  
in Mumbai

**FIRST CASE:** As a student of Ruparel College, she had caught out one of her classmates leading a double life

**PERSONALITY QUIRKS:**  
Unsolved mysteries challenge the fierce streak of obstinacy she was born with

**JOB PROFILE:** Matrimonial and teen issues, job and character verification, surveillance work



BHASKAR PAUL

bling block. Manjiri Prabhu holds that a real-life woman detective is bound to face a lot more mental blocks and opposition from society: “She would find it more difficult to convince people and prove her capabilities than her male counterpart.” But women sleuths don’t always agree. Lahiri claims, “I’ve never faced gender bias. If you have knowledge, confidence and integrity, you’re treated as a professional.”

But they all accept that hardcore crimes don’t usually come their way. Pandit still cherishes the memory of a 1992 crime, when she impersonated as a domestic help with a family where the lady of the house had poisoned her husband. “I won an award for it,” she sighs. But for the regular cases, she doesn’t need to carry her gun or worry about personal safety. Women investigators are mostly required to gather information, interview sources, sift through data and sometimes keep watch on a target. “That, too, you can’t shadow late at night,” says Malathy. “You’ll end up drawing attention to yourself. No woman in India roams around alone at night.” But to Lahiri, it’s not just women. Most private eyes in India operate from the periphery. “The main work is done by the police. Unlike in the West, we’re not licensed.” The Private Investigators Bill pending with the Parliament may

change all that, she hopes.

But a woman also has a special edge. “Most crimes in our cities are crimes of pressure, hypocrisy and concealment within the domestic sphere,” says Swaminathan. “Women understand that the best.” No wonder, most women seem to have a larger purpose, linked to questions of community, corruptions of modern life, failure of institutions, big city loneliness and even women’s identity. Paliwal feels good when she thinks of the girl she rescued in Orissa (“I changed her life. They keep a photograph of me at home”). Pandit likes giving “*ilaj*” to other lives. “We are not the tough women of fiction,” smiles Malathy. “We are just normal women who have the wherewithal to help others.” Lahiri sums it up: “Sleuthing is more a passion than a job for me.”

Women sleuths might not be dipping their toes in the perilous waters of sensational evil, but each narrates her own story of dark and compelling sins committed within confining walls. And at a time when family crimes enthrall the nation, perhaps, there’s more to learn from them than we realise. The coming together of women sleuths, in fact and fiction, points to the spirit of the times—the need to lock horns with the worst criminal within the home, in the most professional manner possible. ■

**THE BEAUTIFUL MNC EXECUTIVE TURNED OUT TO BE A MAID SERVANT. THE MARRIAGE WAS CALLED OFF. THE HARDEST PART WAS IN TELLING HER FIANCE. HE WAS HEARTBROKEN.**